Storytelling Basics: Key Elements of a Great Story

Before we focus on the 60-second format, let's cover the **fundamentals of storytelling**. Every great story, whether it's a 2-hour film or a 10-second anecdote, shares common elements. Understanding these basics will help you craft a mini-story that feels complete and satisfying.

1. Character: A story needs a **who**. This could be a person, an animal, or even an object – often called the **hero** or protagonist. In a one-minute video, your character might be *you* (telling a personal story), or someone else that the audience can focus on. The key is to have a **relatable character**. Viewers should quickly know *who* the story is about and care about them. In short videos, you have seconds to establish this, so sometimes it's implied rather than explicitly stated. (For example, if your video is a first-person story, the viewer assumes you are the character.)

2. Goal or Desire: Give your character a purpose. What do they want or need? Maybe they want to solve a problem, learn something, achieve a goal, or overcome a challenge. In short form content, this goal can be simple: *find something*, *fix something*, *escape something*, *try something new*, etc. The audience doesn't need every detail, but they need a sense of what the character is aiming for, so the rest of the story has direction.

3. Conflict or Challenge: This is the heart of any story – the **problem** or obstacle that makes the journey interesting. If nothing goes wrong or nothing changes, you don't really have a story; you just have a sequence of events. Conflict can be external (a challenge, an opponent, a difficult situation) or internal (fear, doubt, a tough choice). In a one-minute story, you'll want to introduce the conflict *very quickly*. This could be as simple as a single sentence or visual that hints at the problem. For example: "**I had only 60 seconds to catch the train, but…**" – we immediately know there's a challenge. Conflict creates tension and raises a question that keeps viewers hooked: *"What will happen next?"*

4. Resolution: Finally, a story needs some form of resolution or payoff. The conflict doesn't have to be fully solved (especially in a super short story, you might end on a cliffhanger or a punchline), but there should be some sense of progression. The resolution is **how the story ends** – the outcome of the character facing the conflict. Maybe they succeed, maybe they fail, or maybe they learn a lesson. In a one-minute video, the resolution might be a clever twist, a surprise result, or a clear lesson or call-to-action. It's the answer to the question that the conflict raised. A good resolution gives the audience a feeling of closure or a takeaway.

5. Message (Theme/Purpose): Many great stories have an underlying message or theme – basically, *why does this story matter?* In a short video, your "message" might be the lesson learned, the point you're making, or the emotion you want to leave with the viewer. It could be inspirational ("never give up"), cautionary ("look before you leap"), humorous ("things don't always go as planned"), or promotional ("this product can solve your problem"). Identifying the core message helps you stay focusedstoryleague.com.au. Since you have limited time, **stick to one main message** and let everything in the story support it. If you try to cram in multiple unrelated points, the story can feel aimless or overwhelm the viewerstoryleague.com.au.

These elements – **Character, Goal, Conflict, Resolution, and Message** – are the building blocks of story. Think of them as ingredients you can compress into even a tiny tale. When planning a one-minute video, it often helps to jot down these basics first: *Who is it about? What do they want? What's the obstacle? How does it end? What's the point?* Even a few words for each will give you a skeleton to work with.